

It's your daily grouse. You need to send off an emergency mail, and your kid, significant other, sibling, or other annoying co-habitant is using the PC for a far less important task. We will not recommend you use your fists to win this battle, instead, we recommend using an Internet connection sharing software to stretch the Net to your laptop.

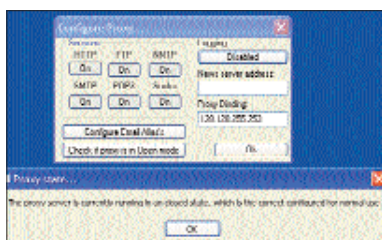
If you have an always-on broadband connection, you need software with advanced features such as Network Address Translation (NAT), shared cache, users and groups, an IP list, etc., since the chances of your system being hacked into increases.

If your work involves applications that deal with streaming audio and video, online accounting, up-to-the-minute stock exchange status or telephone conferencing, you need SyGate, WinGate, or WinProxy, which provide NAT—so many computers can connect to the Internet, using a single public IP—as well as the facility to proxy any port.

## AnalogX

Home or small office users don't use the Internet for anything but surfing and downloading e-mails, and for them we present... AnalogX.

AnalogX is the simplest software we've seen. This is indicated by the interface, which can be worked without documentation—although documentation is provided. There's a red and green signalling system. Green means everything's fine, and red means the proxy has stopped working for some reason.



The 'Check if proxy is in open mode' button, in conjunction with proxy binding, helps you bind the software on the local interface

with no auditing, nor history viewer.

There is a hitch, though. You need to configure the e-mail settings into the Internet sharing aspect. This may be a good feature for system administrators, but for a home-user, it can be irritating if you have several e-mail accounts to configure.

The proxy binding feature reduces the possibility of misuse by external users on the Internet to an absolute zero—the server listens to requests only on the interface specified, which is unavailable to external users.

Just like the interface of the program, configuring client-side settings is simple too. You just need to specify the proxy settings in your browser with the IP address and default port.

- + Free; includes proxy binding
- Logging interface insufficient

**Price:** Free  
**Web site:** [www.analogx.com/contents/download/network/proxy.htm](http://www.analogx.com/contents/download/network/proxy.htm)

### AnalogX

**B**

|             |       |
|-------------|-------|
| Performance | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Features    | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Ease of Use | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Overall     | ▶▶▶▶▶ |

Suppose connection speeds drop in a largish network, say your office, which has around 20 computers. You wouldn't know whether a colleague is clogging up the pipe, or if you're getting less bandwidth from the ISP. Then you need software that monitors bandwidth, and also has the capability to restrict usage by individual users. Two such are DU Meter and Bandwidth Controller. Bandwidth monitoring and management tools can help you towards making important decisions regarding the packages you use—these software could provide you insight on bandwidth utilised or unutilised.

Imagine yet another scenario: you've taken the initiative to set up a small network, shared amongst your friends, in your apartment building. You want to distribute an Internet connection amongst all users. Here, too, you could use SyGate or WinGate.

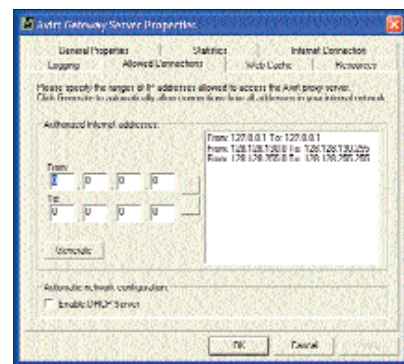
The point is, whatever your scenario, you'll find software specifically designed for the purpose. Keep reading...

## Avirt Gateway

Unlike AnalogX, this software can be run as a service under Windows NT, 2000 and XP. Security enforcement is based on the whitelist concept. Avirt Gateway is wizard-oriented, and has wizards for each operation, right from installation, to starting and stopping the server. Everything is taken care of in the elaborate installation process: enabling and disabling of services such as HTTP, FTP, POP3, SMTP, HTTPS, SOCKS, NNTP, Telnet and even IRC proxy. There's support for audio and video streaming.

In the advanced settings, you can enable and disable any of the 20 ports supported. What's more, you can change the default ports on which the service runs. If you use a port number of your own choice, you reduce the possibility of hacking via known vulnerabilities. You can set up proxy cascading in the installation. Settings may be customised after installation.

This software provides installation for the server and for the client. The advantage is two-fold—you don't have to worry about the nitty-gritty of the settings, which are taken care by the client installer; and when you have a client installer, you need to explicitly set up a client, so an unknown user can't misuse Internet access.



You can specify either a single IP or a range of permissible IPs

- + Client installation
- Lacks auditing as well as history viewing capabilities

**Price:** Single user – \$139.95  
**Web site:** [www.avirt.com](http://www.avirt.com)

### Avirt Gateway

**B**

|             |       |
|-------------|-------|
| Performance | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Features    | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Ease of Use | ▶▶▶▶▶ |
| Overall     | ▶▶▶▶▶ |